

REPUBLICANISM

ABCs of politics – Session 4

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SESSION OUTLINE

- Republicanism = modern nemesis of liberalism
 - Objective: preservation of Ancient freedom ("positive freedom" / "freedom to") against liberal predominance of negative freedom
1. What is the republican political ontology?
 2. What are the origins of republicanism?
 3. What are the modern forms of republicanism?
 4. What are its contemporary perspectives?

THE MAIN FEATURES OF REPUBLICANISM

- ***Predominance of the community***
 - Ontological / Anthropological □ community comes first (social dimension of human beings)
 - Normative □ social relations are self-fulfilling
- Social contract is mainly ***horizontal***
 - State is not a third-party but rather the mean of realization of the political community
- Individuals are ***citizens***
 - Formal: people have individual rights
 - Normative: active participation is a duty and should seek the Common good
- ***Substantial conception*** of the good
 - Ethical conception of politics

	Liberalism	Republicanism
<i>Author</i>	Locke	Rousseau
<i>Anthropology</i>	Methodological individualism	Methodological holism
<i>Motive of individual actions</i>	Utility	Virtu
<i>Conception of freedom</i>	Negative (freedom from)	Positive (freedom to)
<i>Role of the State</i>	Secure basic rights and freedoms	Offer conditions of an ethical life within a political community
<i>Medium of politics</i>	Market	Agora
<i>Conception of members of the community</i>	Legal persons	“Citizens”

THE ORIGINS OF REPUBLICANISM

Aristotle = democratic ideal of Ancient Greece

Human beings as *zoon politikon*

Ethical conception of the political

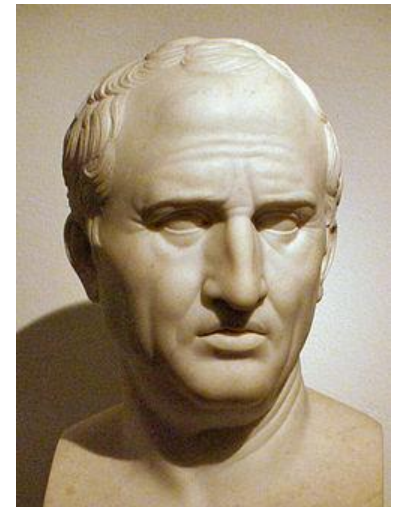
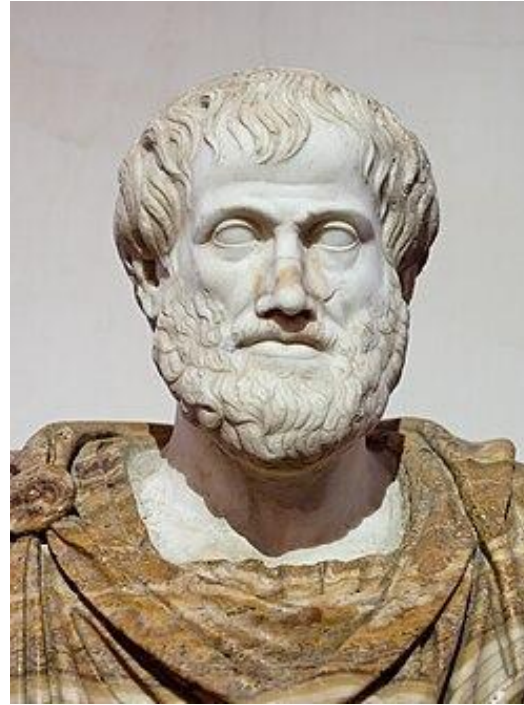
Distinction between public and private

Roman Republic (Cicero)

The political must seek common interest of the people

Power = magistrates and Senate

Mix constitution



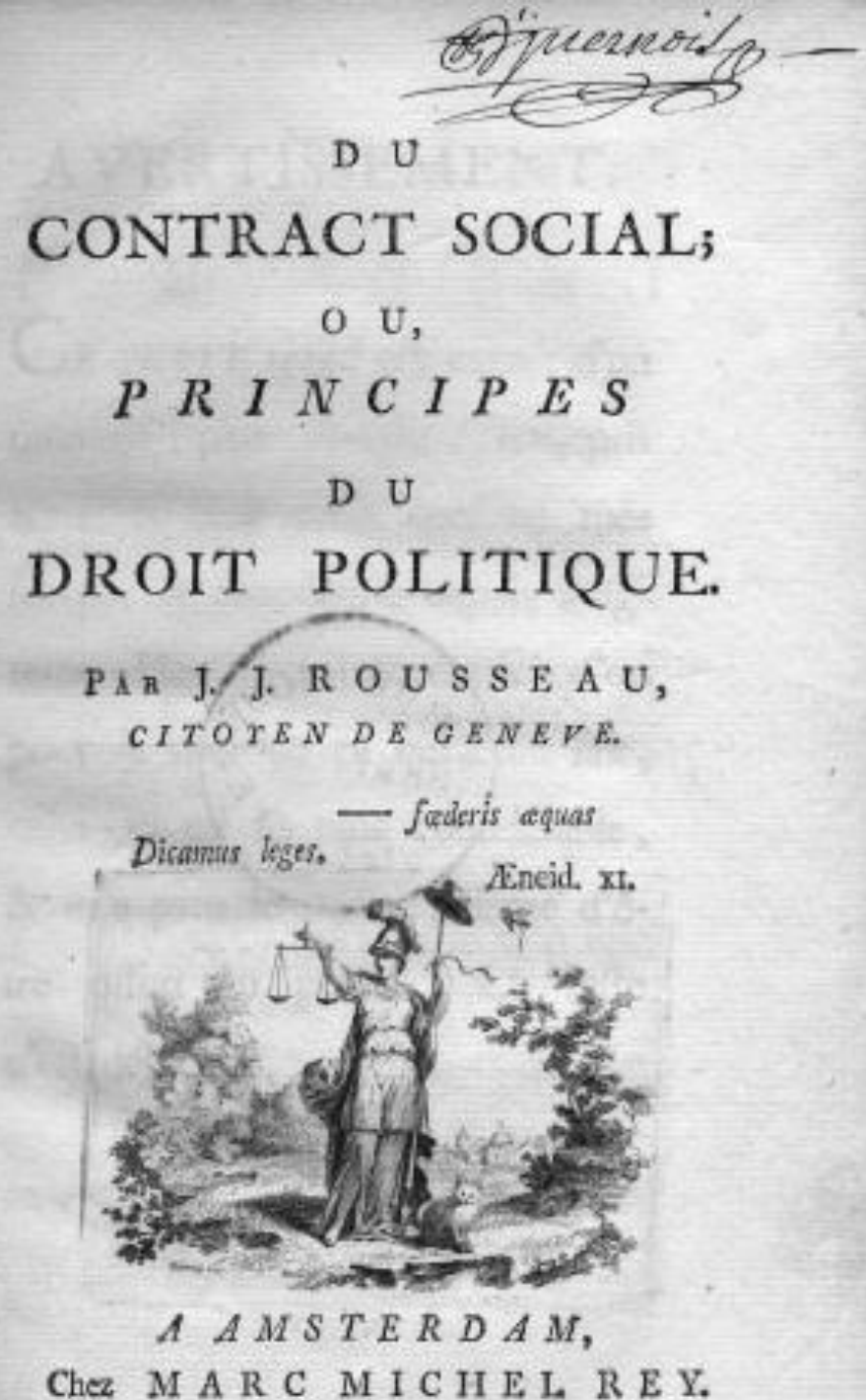


ITALIAN REVIVAL OF REPUBLICANISM

- Italian Renaissance and the revival of the *vita activa*
 - Palmieri (1406-1475)
 - Salutati (1331-1406)
 - Leonardo Bruni (1370-1444)
- Decisive contribution of Macchiavelli
 - Defence of the superiority of the Republic
 - Conflictual republicanism
 - Central role of the *plebs*

ROUSSEAU AND MODERN REPUBLICAN CONTRACTUALISM

- Jean-Jacques Rousseau
- State of problem: transition from natural to social freedom
- “To find a form of association which will defend and protect with the whole common force the person and goods of each associate, and in which each, while uniting with all, may still obey only himself, and remain as free as before.” (*On the social contract*)



THE SOCIAL CONTRACT

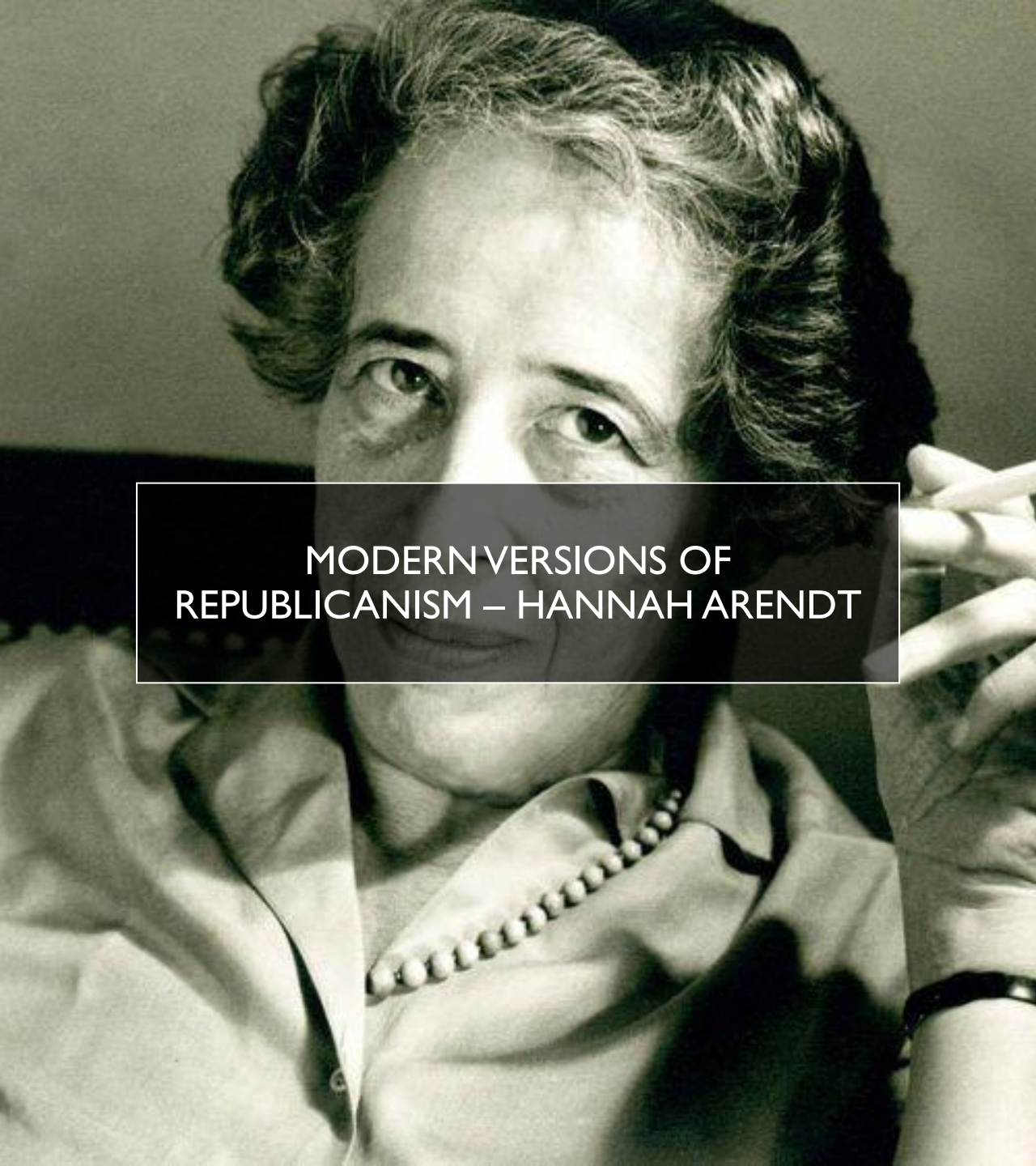
- Duality of the social contract: alienation of individual freedom vs higher stage of freedom:

“Each of us puts in common his person and all his power under the supreme direction of the general will; and we receive each member as an indivisible part of the whole”

- Concept of popular sovereignty:
 - Inalienable
 - Indivisible
 - General will (*volonté générale*)

LIMITS?

- Concept of sovereignty related to the process of secularization □ sovereign as the earthly version of God
- Political and institutional questions remains unsolved
 - Substantive vision of the common good
 - Indivisibility of general will □ what about conflict?
 - Unity of the general will □ tyranny of the majority?

A black and white portrait of Hannah Arendt. She has short, dark, wavy hair and is looking slightly to the right of the camera with a gentle smile. She is wearing a light-colored, possibly white, button-down shirt with a dark collar. A string of small, light-colored beads is draped around her neck. Her right hand is raised near her face, with fingers slightly curled. The background is a plain, light-colored wall.

MODERN VERSIONS OF REPUBLICANISM – HANNAH ARENDT

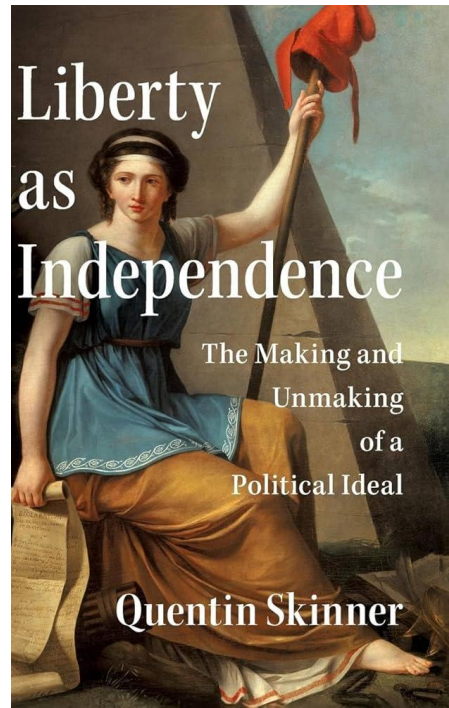
- Arendt (1906-1975)
- Conceptual distinction between *vita contemplativa* (philosophy) and *vita activa* (three components)
 - Labor: biological needs (*animal laborans*)
 - Work: production of objects (*homo faber*)
 - Action: political activity (*zoon politikon*)
- Two main problems:
 - Divorce between philosophy and politics
 - Reduction of the political to the social

THE PUBLIC AND THE PRIVATE

- Central conceptual distinction for the Ancients = public vs private sphere
 - Private realm = the household (*oikos*)
 - Sphere of necessity
 - Necessary but no normative value
 - Foundation of the polis
 - Public realm = political realm (*polis*)
 - Sphere of freedom
 - Equality but its members
 - Ethical sphere

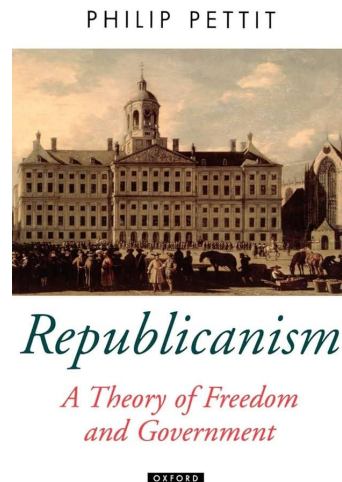
RISE OF THE SOCIAL

- Problem of modernity = rise of the social (neither public nor private)
 - Blurs the distinction between public and private
 - Rise of the economy, intervention of the State in the economy (privatization of the public)
 - Growing intervention in the private sphere / biopolitical turn (publicization of the private)
 - Normative reversal between public and private
 - Rise of liberalism = self-realization through the private rather than the public
 - Risk of “worldlessness” □ disappearance of politics as shared world
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=a_QP22D3wGc



RETHINKING FREEDOM BEYOND LIBERALISM

- Quentin Skinner
 - Main problem of liberalism = failure to acknowledge the positive dimension of “freedom to”
 - Civic engagement necessary to preserve negative freedom
- Philipp Pettit
 - Freedom as “non-domination” rather than non-interference
 - Expression of non-domination in new social movements
- Common idea □ avoid the opposition between liberalism and republicanism



JÜRGEN HABERMAS

THE THEORY OF COMMUNICATIVE ACTION

HABERMAS – ANOTHER
HYBRID FORM

Volume Two

**Lifeworld and System:
A Critique of
Functionalist Reason**

Translated by
Thomas McCarthy

- Habermas: successor of the Frankfurt School
- Critique to liberalism □ political issues as market
- Critique to republicanism □ essentialism
- Solution = solidarity through discussion
 - Role of Public Sphere
 - Ethics of communication □ universalization process
- Post-national concept of identity = constitutional patriotism